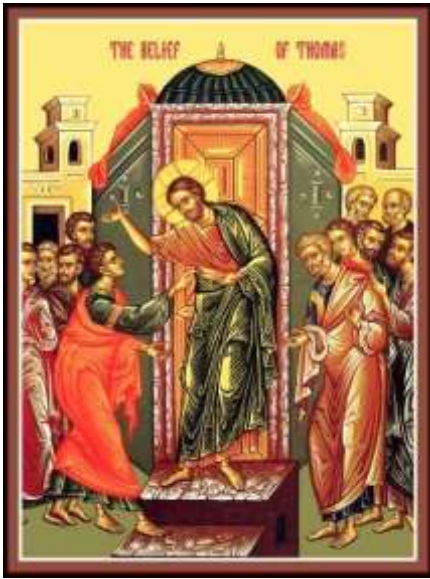


What is the point of St Thomas Sunday?

A little bit

2018-04-14

Synopsis: A "little bit" about the core meaning of St. Thomas Sunday, and how to apply this to our daily lives.



St. Thomas Sunday is the Second Sunday of Pascha. That means that it's the Sunday that immediately follows Pascha, or the "eight day" of Pascha (When Orthodox Christians count days, they always count the first day of something as number 1. For instance, three days after the death of someone includes the day of their death among the numbering.)

This Sunday we read the story of St Thomas and his doubt and how Jesus appeared to him on the 8th day after the resurrection. This story is only in the Gospel of St. John (John 20:19-31)

It's important to be able to read the Gospel or anything in the Bible, or for that matter anything -- including a textbook or newspaper article and understand the core meaning. Regarding the Bible, there are many meanings that are very useful to the soul but we must at least understand the core meaning and it should be something relatively easy to see.

What is the core meaning of the reading for St Thomas Sunday?

Basically, put in a somewhat crude way, it is this: you must **do the work**, and never give up. Faith is not that you always absolutely believe everything perfectly and do everything perfectly but that you *keep doing the work*. That's not particularly a popular idea in modern-day Christianity, but it's the only way that things get done. In Christianity, remember, the "thing" that we are trying to get done is the perfection of our soul so that we can abide in the presence of God and know Him, eternally.

Thomas was not there when the Lord appeared to the disciples on the day of the resurrection. Of course, the disciples would have been telling him over and over "We have seen the Lord" but Thomas could not believe this. We should not judge him for this, because the idea that a person who had just recently been hanging naked on a cross could rise from the dead was too fantastic for Thomas to believe and most of us would have suffered as well from disbelief. Deep sorrow makes it very difficult to believe, but not to continue *doing the work*.

Even though Thomas did not believe, *he wanted to*. Because he had such love for the Lord, having been with Him for over 3 years, he hung around. It must have been very difficult for him to hear over and over "We have seen the Lord" and for him to feel a great stabbing pain and void in his heart because he could not believe. He had no way of knowing that on the eighth day the Lord would appear to him and he would be able to fully believe.

Certainly, there are other things in the story of Saint Thomas that are very useful, but everything radiates out of Thomas doing the work. The Lord even gently criticizes him saying that there are those who have not seen and believe, and they are greater. Fair enough. But most of us don't consider ourselves to be so fantastic and so special. We need to study hard to get an A on a test. We need to work hard to get things done. We have moments of doubt, and laziness, and sin, and terrible feelings in our hearts. And yet we still want to call ourselves Christians. Is this justified? It is: as long as we act like Thomas. As long as we struggle to believe but also keep doing the work.

His patience was rewarded because on the 8th day the Lord appeared to him and wiped away all of his unbelief. We have a saying about Thomas' unbelief: we call it: "believing unbelief". This reminds me very much of the man who had a son who was a demoniac: he said to the Lord: "I believe, help my unbelief".

This is a realistic appraisal of the way we live our Christian lives. Sometimes we read about the Saints, and I think some of us get demoralized thinking we can't do any of the things because we're not perfect and we make all kinds of mistakes. There are days we don't even say our prayers or we break the fast or we do a sin that we know we shouldn't be doing. This is the "unbelief" in us, our weakness and brokenness. Thomas was broken by the events of the crucifixion but he still had love and he still *did the work*.

That's the core message of St Thomas Sunday. *Keep doing the work*.

What is this work?

First of all, it is living according to the truth as best we can. If we know what we should do we should try to do it. We know that we should pray, and especially pray for our enemies. Whether or not we're good at this we should do it, and if we skip it today we should find a way to not skip it tomorrow.

We know that we should read the scriptures. Most people get demoralized about this because they don't understand the scriptures. *Keep doing the work*. You will really be rewarded. Understanding the scriptures is not an intellectual exercise. If we read them enough and we struggle to follow them enough the Lord will reveal them to us.

Perhaps we have trouble fasting or we don't see the results from fasting. *Keep doing the work*. Perhaps we're not good at fasting and we slip up. *Keep doing the work*. When we're able to fast we should do it, and on the fast days that we don't fast we should try to fast. If you don't fast, at least you're trying.

There is a fundamental Christian fact that unfortunately most people do not fundamentally understand. If you keep *doing the work* God will reward you. The *reward will always happen*, and it may be *unexpected* like it was for St Thomas on the 8th day of the Resurrection.

Source: <http://www.orthodox.net/a-little-bit/alb-saint-thomas-sunday-take-home.pdf>

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Tags: A Little Bit; Thomas Sunday; Faith; Struggle; Matins Gospels; Spiritual Life;

There are many articles about "A little bit" of some aspect of Christianity, designed to help us learn in small, manageable pieces. I welcome suggestions for other topics, and commentary. Please read some: <http://www.orthodox.net/a-little-bit>, Priest Seraphim Holland, seraphim@orthodox.net